

UPDATED: March 7th, 2026



COOL BRITANNIA: THE BATTLE OF BRITPOP
BACKGROUND GUIDE

TRITONMUN XXXI – APRIL 12TH, 2026

MODEL UNITED NATIONS AT UNIVERSITY OF CALIFORNIA, SAN DIEGO

TABLE OF CONTENTS

Head Chair Letter.....	2
Vice Chair Letter.....	3
Position Paper Guidelines.....	4
Rules of Procedure.....	7
Key Terms.....	9
Historical Background.....	10
Character Profiles.....	19
Questions to Consider.....	26
Closing Remarks.....	27
Works Cited.....	28

HEAD CHAIR LETTER

Greetings, delegates!

Welcome to *Cool Britannia: The Battle of Britpop* (1995). My name is Lydia Flynn and I'll be your Head Chair for this Specialised Committee in this iteration of TritonMUN XXXI.

I am a sophomore at UCSD, currently pursuing a double major in History and Political Science: Comparative Politics with a minor in Classical Studies. I'm from Worcestershire, UK (about two hours northwest of London). This is my second time chairing in MUN, but my first time chairing a specialised committee such as this one.

My MUN experience started properly when I came to UCSD back in September 2024. I participated in my high school's MUN team for two years, but not to a high level. My main area was speech and debate – British Parliamentary style – and I competed at a national level in the UK for two years, debating at the University of Nottingham, University of Oxford, and the ESU Schools' Mace.

Music has always been a huge part of my life. I have been playing piano since I was 7 years old and bass guitar since I was 12. I have a deep appreciation for a wide range of music, and my favourite bands include The Smiths, The Stone Roses, New Order, Echo & the Bunnymen, Slowdive, and many others (plus, of course, Blur and Oasis). In this vein, this committee is a kind of passion project for me. I was raised on the sounds of British alternative rock. What you'll come to see, however, is that this committee is not just about music.

The Battle of Britpop is set against the background of a rapidly shifting Britain. Whether you're a more seasoned delegate or a MUN newcomer, I highly encourage all of you to jump head-first into the world of *Cool Britannia* by working with your fellow delegates, coming together to pass directives, and listening to some of the (subjectively) best music around.

I hope that all of you have as much fun participating as I did creating this committee. If you have any questions, concerns, or comments, please don't hesitate to email me.

Kind regards,

Lydia Flynn (lcflynn@ucsd.edu)

VICE CHAIR LETTER

Hello delegates!

My name is Lyn Tai, and I'll be your Vice Chair for TritonMUN XXXI Cool Britannica.

I am a first-year student at UCSD, majoring in Psychology with a specialisation in Social Psychology and minoring in Political Science. I'm from the LA/OC area, and have been in Model UN since I was a freshman in high school. Even though I've been in MUN for about 5 years now, this is my second time chairing and first time in a specialised committee. In high school, I mainly competed in high school conferences, but I have experience in college and international conferences as well! Outside of MUN, I enjoy reading and hiking in my free time, and I work as a nail tech here on campus.

I have always grown up around music, and played several growing up instruments such as piano, electric guitar, trumpet, and guzheng. Personally, my music taste has always been very mixed, but some of my favourite artists right now are Mitski, Doja Cat, En, and TV Girl.

I hope all of you guys have lots of fun in this committee and focus on fostering an environment of collaboration and engaging debate!

Best Wishes,

Lyn Tai (11tai@ucsd.edu)

POSITION PAPER GUIDELINES

TRITONMUN POSITION PAPER GUIDELINES

- Position Papers are due on **April 3rd at 11:59pm.**
 - Requests for extensions must be sent by the advisor to TritonMUN by **March 22nd.**
- Position Papers must be submitted to the **Google Form** linked here:
 - <https://forms.gle/eme7iiESbSEGaZgx9>
- Format.
 - Papers should be double-spaced in Times New Roman 12 pt. font and include no pictures.
 - At the top of each paper, include your country/person, name, committee, and topic.
 - Required* Sections: Each of these sections should be clearly labeled
 - Background
 - Past Actions by the Committee (if applicable)
 - Position of your Country/Person
 - Possible Solutions

*Some committees may ask for different formatting or an alternative to a position paper altogether, this will be clearly noted in the background guide for that committee

RULES OF PROCEDURE

This committee will function as a hybrid between crisis and GA. There will be some crisis updates *but no backroom*. Committee will be driven by the directives and decisions of the delegates in frontroom. The frequency of the crisis updates is up to the discretion of the chair. The aim of this committee is not to form one large resolution at the end, but to have a handful of directives over the course of the conference.

The title of this committee comes from August 14, 1995. Oasis and Blur, two of the most popular Britpop bands in the UK, are set to release their singles on the same day – Oasis with *Roll With It* and Blur with *Country House*. The atmosphere is buzzing: the ultimate question is, ‘Blur or Oasis?’

You, delegates, are reading this on **August 7, 1995** – only **one week** until the releases of *Roll With It* and *Country House*. Your task? Divide and conquer. Someone must emerge victorious in earning the title of No. 1 single. In this committee, your job is to, firstly, field the court of public opinion. What your characters do, publish, broadcast, say, and so on, can make or break the futures of these two bands. Secondly, you must navigate the complexities of British society and its new place in an increasingly globalised world. This means figuring out the intersections of class, geopolitics, and music.

Technology Policy:

This committee will be 100% *technology free*. This means that there will be no usage of laptops, phones, or iPads at any time during committee. Speeches, notes, and directives must be drafted on paper. Delegates may print off the background guide if they wish for reference in committee, but there must not be any prewriting (i.e., absolutely no drafting of directives and speeches prior to committee). Short notes, annotations, and extra information are permitted.

Furthermore, the use of generative AI in any capacity **is strictly prohibited**, as adhering to the TritonMUN conference-wide policy. This includes during research, since AI often provides incorrect information. All work and opinions expressed are expected to be entirely your own.

Delegates are *highly encouraged* to bring lots of lined paper, spare pens/pencils, and sticky notes.

Failure to adhere to this technology policy in any way will result in disciplinary action and escalation to the Upper Secretariat.

Extra Sensitivity Note on Characters:

While the majority of the character list is apolitical, there are a few political figures. With this in mind, delegates must be mindful of the characters they are representing. Absolutely no mention to controversies beyond the immediate committee or political actions taking place in the future are permitted. Delegates must stay relevant to the topic at hand. **Failure to do so will result in interference from the Chair and possibly escalation to the Upper Secretariat.**

DEI AND AI POLICIES

Sensitivity & Harassment Policy:

TritonMUN is committed to fostering a healthy environment for diplomacy and dialogue, and upholding standards of diversity, equity, and inclusion for all delegates. Harassment or disruptive behavior of any kind—whether verbal or non-verbal, in or out of committee—is strictly prohibited. All attendees and staffers should be treated with equal respect, and discrimination on the basis of race, color, gender identity, sexual orientation, religion, nationality, ethnicity, or physical/mental disability will not be tolerated. This list is not exhaustive, and should not be treated as such. **Please report any instances of harassment to conference staff, either directly or through the Anonymous Feedback Form.**

In addition, we acknowledge that topics discussed in-committee may be politically sensitive, particularly in Specialized and Crisis Committees. While we understand that delegates may be immersed in the action and setting of their committee, delegates must maintain decorum and

refrain from inflammatory language and actions, even when doing so may be historically accurate to one's character, group, or country. When drafting crisis directives, delegates should refrain from pursuing any action that explicitly violates human rights, including—but not limited to—enslavement and genocide. **Please refer to your committee's background guide for specific sensitivity statements and guidelines, and direct any questions to the committee's head chair.**

All attendants should observe these policies during the entirety of the conference, even outside formal debate, including opening/closing ceremonies, "FUNMUN", etc. Please note that violation of these policies may result in consequences such as disqualification from awards and contact towards the delegate's Advisor. At TritonMUN, our goal has always been focused on the delegate's abilities to enjoy and have fun in committee. However, in order to truly enjoy TritonMUN, delegates must feel safe in committee, which starts with respecting one another.

Plagiarism & Generative AI Policy:

TritonMUN recognizes that Model United Nations provides a space for aspiring leaders to showcase their work and abilities, and that all delegates wish to be evaluated in a fair and accurate manner. As such, we expect all delegates to perform with integrity and refrain from plagiarizing the work of their peers. This includes—but is not limited to—claiming the work of another delegate as one's own, including another bloc's unique clause without prior approval from the original writer, and replacing another's work with one's own (i.e. overwriting).

In addition, delegates are strictly prohibited from utilizing generative AI to produce position papers, resolutions, and directives, in part or in their entirety.

Resolution Work Outside of Committee:

TritonMUN wishes that all delegates use their breaks and downtime as intended: to connect, relax, and refresh. While not in committee, delegates are strictly prohibited from working on

resolutions and directives. In addition, this means that pre-writing, or preparing resolutions and directives before the start of the conference, is strictly prohibited.

Technology Policy:

Delegates should expect the use of technology to be limited during committee sessions. Instead of having a universal technology policy for TritonMUN, such policies are individualized for each committee and set by their daises. Please refer to each committee's background guide to understand their technology policies, and direct any questions to the committee's head chair. Repercussive actions will be taken at the discretion of the head chair.

KEY TERMS

1. *Britpop* – a major musical movement of the late 1980s into the 1990s in the UK, influenced by 1960s bands like The Beatles and The Kinks, often seen as a reaction to the stadium rock of the 1980s and American grunge. Emblematic bands included Blur, Oasis, Pulp, Suede, the Happy Mondays, and Elastica.
2. *‘Cool Britannia’* – a play on the term ‘Rule Britannia,’ denoting the UK’s new place as the cultural leader of the world, including output of music, film, and fashion. It also referred to the UK’s economic rise and newfound prosperity within the European Union and the world after the end of the Cold War.
3. *European Union (EU)* – European intergovernmental organisation consisting of 15 member states as of 1 January, 1995. The UK was the second largest EU member state at the time in both economy and population, marking it as a significant power.
4. *Euroscepticism* – a political alignment consisting of anti-EU sentiment, ranging from less involvement with the EU, such as less centralisation (soft euroscepticism), to outright opposition to the EU and advocating for leaving it (hard euroscepticism). It often comes with concerns over immigration, sovereignty, and bureaucracy.
5. *Deindustrialisation* – the decline of the industrial sector of an economy, including measures such as the shutting down of factories, nonalignment/noncompliance with trade unions, cutback of wages and hours, and the extraction of manual labour moving overseas.
6. *Conservative Party (or the ‘Tories’)* – one of the two major British political parties, on the centre-right. Ideologically aligns with the ownership of private property, reduced public spending, and reduced taxation.
7. *Labour Party* – the other of the two major British political parties, on the centre-left. Ideologically aligns with increased public spending and social provision (e.g., affordable housing and socialised healthcare), social justice, and working with trade unions.

***COOL BRITANNIA: THE BATTLE OF BRITPOP* HISTORICAL BACKGROUND**

DEINDUSTRIALISATION, THE NORTH-SOUTH DIVIDE & POST-PUNK

In 1996, the American journalist Stryker McGuire wrote a cover story for *Newsweek* called ‘London Rules’, proclaiming London to be ‘the coolest city on the planet.’ He attributed the UK’s economic growth to the post-Thatcherite¹ policies that dominated the 1980s.² Socially, however, Prime Minister Margaret Thatcher’s policies were unpopular with the working class.

Margaret Thatcher was the Prime Minister of the UK between 1979 and 1990. During her term, rapid deindustrialisation was at the top of the Conservative Party’s agenda in order to favour the growth of the tertiary sector (e.g., service jobs like finance, education, research, and so on) in large urban areas in the south of England, like London, Oxford, and Bristol. This included the privatisation of state-owned industries, curbing the influence of trade unions, wiping out around 15% of the UK’s industrial base, and the shutting down of factories. These deindustrialisation measures also led to severe inequality. In 1979, Britain’s economic inequality was at a postwar low, but by 1991, the inequality between the richest and poorest had reached an all-time high.³ This inequality was most felt in the north of England, where the overwhelming majority of industrial work – such as steel, car manufacturing, and coal – took place. Studies have suggested that the economic ‘leaving behind’ of the north of England also led to a rise in crime rates among young people in these areas.⁴ This perpetuated the north-south divide of

¹ ‘post-Thatcherite’: events/policies happening after Prime Minister Margaret Thatcher’s leadership, whose premiership was characterised by widespread neoliberal economic reforms and reduced public spending

² <https://www.theguardian.com/politics/2009/mar/29/cool-britannia-g20-blair-brown>

³ <https://jacobin.com/2020/12/margaret-thatcher-british-economy-tories-austerity>

⁴ <https://www.theguardian.com/politics/2019/apr/27/margaret-thatcher-industrial-collapse-led-to-crime-rise>

England, with northern England being significantly poorer than the south, the latter of which largely relied on the prosperity of cities like London, Oxford, and Bristol. The 1980s saw numerous strikes and union demonstrations, such as by the National Union of Mineworkers, one



Photo taken at the 1984-85 Miners' Strike, Yorkshire, England
[\(https://socialistalternative.info/2024/03/06/the-story-of-the-1984-85-miners-strike/\)](https://socialistalternative.info/2024/03/06/the-story-of-the-1984-85-miners-strike/)

of the UK's most powerful trade unions. The Miners' Strike of 1984-85 saw the government reacting violently, to the point where parts of Yorkshire and Nottingham resembled 'police states'.⁵

Put simply, political and economic decisions affecting northern England came from London, strengthening the disillusionment the youth in these areas had with the prosperity of the south, juxtaposing their relative deprivation. From this, northern cities such as Manchester, Liverpool, Hull, Newcastle, and York quickly became sites of rapid musical development in the wake of the declining industrial sector. Music was a way for young people to express their

⁵ <https://socialistalternative.info/2024/03/06/the-story-of-the-1984-85-miners-strike/>

frustration, boredom, and anger with the system that had failed them with poor employment opportunities, dwindling educational resources, and very few ways to break free. Consequently, the ‘post-punk’ scene of the 1980s exploded in Manchester, including bands such as Joy Division, The Smiths, and The Chameleons.

Post-punk was characterised by brooding and melancholy lyricism, often invoking imagery of the North’s failing industrial landscapes, and sonically experimental approaches. It also provided a moodier and less aggressive musical alternative to punk. These lyrics from The Smiths’s song *Still Ill*, released on their debut self-titled album in 1984, describe the deprivation and lack of opportunity the working class of Manchester were subjected to:

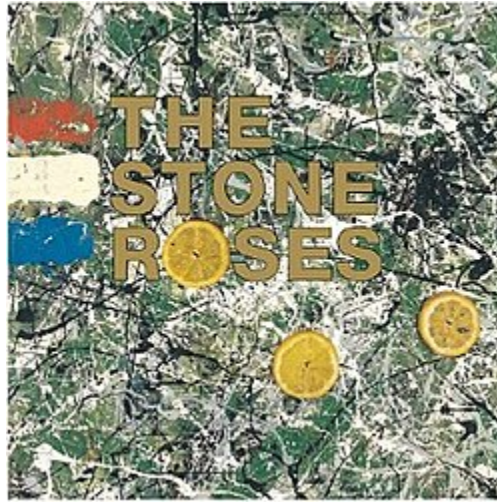
*I decree today that life
Is simply taking and not giving
England is mine, it owes me a living*

The musical mood of the late 1970s (with the release of Joy Division’s first album *Unknown Pleasures*, often cited as the foundation of post-punk) into the late 1980s was dominated by post-punk, with bands such as The Cure (hailing from Crawley, another ‘left behind’ town south of London) and Echo & The Bunnymen (Liverpool) finding success on the charts with this melancholic and brooding indie rock subgenre.

THE STONE ROSES & ‘KEEPING IT LEMON’

In March 1989, however, a band consisting of working-class, Irish Catholic young men from Manchester released their debut album, *The Stone Roses*. The eponymous band soon found themselves at the centre of the ‘Madchester’ movement, where the city of Manchester dominated

the UK's music scene. It was characterised by a distinct shift from the depressing post-punk scene, and is closely associated with the indie dance movement.⁶



Cover of The Stone Roses' debut album, 1989

The Stone Roses found success with their single *Fools Gold*, a musically intriguing blend of distinctive drumming by Alan 'Reni' Wren, Gary 'Mani' Mounfield's soul and funk-inspired bassline, John Squire's psychedelic Jimi Hendrix-esque guitar, and Ian Brown's captivating lyricism and distinct Mancunian accent.

The Stone Roses set themselves apart from post-punk, and are often credited with starting the Britpop musical movement, alongside The La's hit single *There She Goes* (a track with jangly pop guitar reminiscent of the 1960s). Furthermore, the term 'keeping it lemon' refers to the album cover of The Stone Roses' self-titled debut, and soon became a slang term for 'keeping it cool' or 'laid back',⁷ marking the distinct shift in attitude from the music of northern England. Gone was the moody, depressing lyricism of The Smiths' Morrissey and The Cure's

⁶ <https://www.theguardian.com/music/2020/jul/07/1990s-indie-dance-boom-happy-mondays-primal-scream>

⁷ <https://www.standard.co.uk/news/world/keep-it-lemon-meaning-tiktok-trend-b1111940.html>

Robert Smith. Manchester and, by extension, northern England, became the centre of ‘cool’. Tracks from northern bands such as *The Only One I Know* by The Charlatans, *Come Together* by Primal Scream, and *Step On* by The Happy Mondays became the sound of the summer of 1990,⁸ characterised by large outdoor parties and underground raves.

THE POLITICAL MOOD OF THE 1990s

The end of post-punk also directly coincided with the end of Margaret Thatcher’s term as Prime Minister. She was replaced by John Major in November 1990, another member of the Conservative Party. However, his policies were more centrist and contrasted with Thatcher’s staunchly neoliberal stance – he played an important role in the peace negotiations in Northern Ireland nearing the end of The Troubles⁹ and was in charge of British negotiations in the Maastricht Treaty.¹⁰ Despite being an unpopular Prime Minister near the end of his term in the wake of multiple scandals in the Conservative Party,¹¹ Major paved the way for more progressive politics and inadvertently helped the Labour Party win their 1997 landslide victory with Tony Blair at the helm. Overall, Major’s stance ‘looked out’ to Europe and the rest of the world, whereas Thatcher’s policies intended to make the UK more self-sufficient. She supported the EU only to the extent of trading, and vehemently opposed further European integration – in this sense, she represented a more Eurosceptic wing of Tory politics, whereas Major’s perspective encouraged a more globalised and optimistic worldview.

⁸ <https://www.theguardian.com/music/2020/jul/07/1990s-indie-dance-boom-happy-mondays-primal-scream>

⁹ Ethnonationalist conflict in Northern Ireland lasting from the late 1960s to the late 1990s, surrounding whether Northern Ireland should remain part of the UK (Unionists) or become part of the Republic of Ireland (Republicans)

¹⁰ Treaty signed in 1992 officially setting up the European Union and introducing the Euro shared currency

¹¹ <https://www.independent.co.uk/news/the-major-minority-1314246.html>

‘COOL BRITANNIA’ AND THE RISE OF BRITPOP

Alongside this newfound optimism and economic growth in the aftermath of the economically devastating deindustrialisation of the Thatcher years came the emergence of a shift in British cultural identity: *Cool Britannia*.

‘Cool Britannia’ is a term originating from the eponymous song by the Bonzo Dog Doo Dah Band on their 1967 album, *Gorilla*:

Cool Britannia, Britannia you are cool

Take a trip!

Britons ever, ever, ever shall be hip.

It is a play on words of the term *Rule Britannia*, a British patriotic song.¹² The ‘Cool Britannia’ moment of the 1990s came hand-in-hand with the musical movement of Britpop.

Britpop is perhaps best defined less as a distinctive genre and more as a cultural moment in British society. However, it ‘drew consciously on the tradition of melodic, guitar-based British pop music established by the Beatles’¹³ and is often credited with bringing alternative rock to the mainstream. It was mainly a term given to bands such as Blur, Oasis, Pulp, and Suede by the British press, and seemed to be the counterpart to American grunge (such as Nirvana and Pearl

¹² J. Ayto, *Movers and Shakers: a Chronology of Words that Shaped our Age* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2006), ISBN 0-19-861452-7, p. 233.

¹³ <https://www.britannica.com/art/Britpop>

Jam) and the melancholic, introspective British shoegaze scene (such as Slowdive and My Bloody Valentine).

Some themes in Britpop hold consistent across the groups of the time. For example, bands often sang about the state of British society – not necessarily to make a political statement, but to describe the reality that people lived simply because it was the state of affairs. Have a look at these two songs by Oasis and Blur, respectively.

Cigarettes & Alcohol by Oasis (1994):

Is it worth the aggravation

To find yourself a job when there's nothing worth working for?

The track describes the resignation from employment and trying to find ‘meaning’ through working. Instead, Liam Gallagher proclaims, ‘*But all I need are cigarettes and alcohol!*’ Not working is not portrayed as a negative thing. Instead, it is seen as the state of just how things are, and joy can be found in consuming things that are bad for you. It is freeing, and a direct reaction to the Thatcherite emphasis on being an economically active member of society. It is also important to note here that the members of Oasis grew up working class in Manchester, so they had firsthand experience of the effects deindustrialisation had on the city.

Now, here is a small part of *Parklife* by Blur (1994):

I get up when I want, except on Wednesdays when I get rudely awakened by the dustmen.

I put my trousers on, have a cup of tea and I think about leaving the house.

*I feed the pigeons, I sometimes feed the sparrows too;
It gives me a sense of enormous wellbeing. And then I'm happy for the rest of the day,
Safe in the knowledge there will always be a bit of my heart devoted to it.*

The verse above is spoken by Phil Daniels, an actor who made his name playing the ‘everyman’ role, and he was sought out by Blur to do this part of the track. His accent is a combination of Received Pronunciation (RP)¹⁴ and Cockney¹⁵ – commonly referred to as ‘Estuary English’. The song is not a political statement which is, however, where we can find the political value of it. Blur guitarist Graham Coxon claimed *Parklife* is about ‘having fun and doing what you want to do.’¹⁶ This statement perfectly encapsulates the spirit of Britpop: existence in the UK was not meaningless without work. Instead, there is a type of fulfilment that can be found by just enjoying the mundane, everyday aspects of British life – say, through your ‘parklife.’ This, economically, showed that the UK was on the rise. The cost of living was down and the UK was a key member of the EU. It was becoming more diverse and accepting with an increase of immigration, and Britain was the centre of global cultural output.

Perhaps the best encapsulation of the spirit of Britpop is [this video](#) from a 1995 BBC 2 broadcast, showing Damon Albarn (lead singer of Blur) saying, ‘British bands are no longer embarrassed to sing about where they come from’.

¹⁴ A non-regional accent in the UK often associated with private education and the upper class

¹⁵ Working class London accent associated with the east of the city

¹⁶ <https://www.theguardian.com/culture/2012/jul/16/how-we-made-blur-parklife>

Overall, Britpop was a *distinct cultural shift* away from the nihilism of the 1980s which saw thousands of people losing their jobs and industrial landscapes becoming barren and dilapidated. With the end of the Thatcher era and a political shift changing the way Brits saw the rest of Europe and the world came a newfound optimism and happiness to just *be*. Brits could guiltlessly enjoy the mundane things in life, and this is the sentiment that Britpop often conveyed. Furthermore, the UK was aware of its place as a new cultural powerhouse – being British became ‘cool’ again.

EXTRA RESEARCH

Attached below is a Spotify playlist I have made containing some of the essential tracks of the post-punk and Britpop movements. Delegates should familiarise themselves with some of these songs.

<https://open.spotify.com/playlist/0vaiC1RE11Mg0GcEZ0Hwqm?si=d831abf982554bad>

CHARACTER PROFILES

Note: the Wikipedia articles linked are to give the delegates an idea on how to guide their research. It should not be your only source of information.

1. Damon Albarn – https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Damon_Alborn

Damon Albarn is the creative centre of Blur, acting as the band's lead vocalist, lyricist, and main driver in their musical direction. He helped to shape the sound and aesthetic of the Britpop movement, and he often emphasised distinctly British themes in his songwriting. His rivalry with Oasis, particularly with Noel and Liam Gallagher, was a defining cultural moment of the 1990s music scene in the UK. For further research, delegates should research Blur's albums (such as *Leisure*, *The Great Escape*, and *Modern Life Is Rubbish*) as well as their public image and cultural identity. His persona aligned with the art-school south of England.

2. Graham Coxon - https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Graham_Coxon

Graham Coxon is Blur's lead guitarist and key contributor to their musical style. His guitar work is often very experimental (listen to *Pressure On Julian* off their *Modern Life Is Rubbish* album for an idea of this) and he pushes the band to a more alternative rock sound. Delegates should research his musical influences and the band dynamics of Blur. Have a think about his artistic priorities and how this might affect the band's responses to commercial pressures and band rivalries.

3. Liam Gallagher – https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Liam_Gallagher

Liam Gallagher is the charismatic and outspoken frontman of Oasis. He is known for his distinctive voice and confrontational personality, often with the press. His public persona and interview style often fuelled media attention and intensified the rivalry between Oasis and Blur. He represents the image and attitude of Oasis to fans and the press. For further research, look into Liam's influence on the

band's identity as resonating with the broader north of England and working-class identity. Also have a look into Oasis's songs such as *Cigarettes & Alcohol* and *Married With Children*, both off their 1994 album *Definitely Maybe*.

4. Noel Gallagher – https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Noel_Gallagher

Noel Gallagher is the main songwriter and musical driver of Oasis, as well as Liam's brother. While he is not the frontman, since he plays lead guitar and backing vocals, the band's most successful songs were a result of his writing. He is often the band's spokesperson in interviews and is involved heavily with strategic decisions about the band.

5. David Balfe – https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/David_Balfe

David Balfe founded Food Records, the label responsible for signing and promoting Blur at the height of the Britpop movement. As a record executive, Balfe's role revolves around Blur's commercial strategy and coordination with larger companies for record distribution. His decisions could influence marketing campaigns, release schedules, and the broader public perception of the band. A way to research his role is to understand how independent ('indie') labels worked with larger music corporations in the 1990s and how this affected bands' popularity.

6. Alan McGee – https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Alan_McGee

Alan McGee founded Creation Records and is best known for discovering and signing Oasis. He is a crucial figure in promoting the Britpop movement and bringing Oasis into mainstream popularity. He takes risks in signing new artists and this gives him a certain reputation in the music industry. Understanding his priorities in the signing of new artists as well as his specific approach to the development of talent can guide delegates in how he might promote Oasis.

7. Colin Southgate – https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Colin_Southgate

Colin Southgate serves as Chairman of EMI UK, one of the largest music companies in the world. EMI has the resources to distribute records globally and can heavily influence which artists achieve commercial success. As chairman, Southgate would focus on profitability, market trends, and keeping EMI at the forefront of record distribution. Have a look into how corporate record labels worked with indie ones during the 1990s music industry, and how Southgate may approach artist promotion and competition in the industry.

8. Rob Dickins – https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Rob_Dickins

Rob Dickins is the leader of Warner Music UK, a major competitor to EMI in the British market. His role involves identifying successful artists and maintaining Warner's competitive advantage. Dickins has significant influence over marketing budgets and partnerships in the music industry. Further research should include understanding the competitive landscape and how to respond to rival labels.

9. Stuart Maconie – https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Stuart_Maconie

Stuart Maconie is a journalist for *NME*, one of the most influential music publications in the UK (whose cover is the photo of this committee on the TritonMUN website!). Journalists like Maconie play a major role in shaping public opinion about bands and musical trends. He could also influence how the general public perceive the Britpop movement through interviews, music reviews, and commentary.

10. Steve Sutherland – <https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/NME> (does not have his own Wikipedia page but is mentioned throughout this article)

Steve Sutherland serves as editor of *NME*, meaning he has significant control over its editorial direction. As editor, he decides which bands receive coverage and how stories about the music industry can be framed. His choices can influence which artists gain credibility within the alternative and mainstream music scenes.

Further research could include understanding the role of music publications in promoting new artists in the 1990s and the editorial power of *NME*.

11. Piers Morgan – https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Piers_Morgan (a controversial figure; only focus on his actions relevant to committee)

Piers Morgan is editor of *News of the World*, a controversial and popular British tabloid newspaper. Tabloids often focused on sensational stories about celebrities and musicians. Morgan's publication could amplify rivalries, scandals, or personal conflicts in the industry. Delegates should research tabloid journalism and its influence on celebrity culture in the 1990s – how tabloids shape narratives could help determine how he might cover events in the Britpop scene.

12. Stuart Higgins – https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Stuart_Higgins

Stuart Higgins is editor-in-chief of *The Sun*, Britain's leading tabloid. The publication plays a major role in shaping public opinion on politics, entertainment, and cultural trends. Higgins's editorial decisions could affect national conversation surrounding Britpop and its leading bands. Delegates should look into the influence of *The Sun* and its approach to sensationalism.

13. Paul du Noyer – https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Paul_Du_Noyer

Paul du Noyer serves as editor of *Q*, a well-respected music magazine. Its publications go into detail on coverage of artists and the industry. Compared to tabloids, *Q* focuses on more serious journalism and cultural analysis. Du Noyer's approach could shape how critics and fans understand Britpop and its cultural relevance. Further research could include *Q*'s reputation and readership, and how this may affect how du Noyer approaches coverage of the chart rivalry.

14. Chris Evans – [https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Chris_Evans_\(presenter\)](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Chris_Evans_(presenter))

Chris Evans is the host of the BBC Radio 1 Breakfast Show, one of the most widely listened to radio programmes in the UK. Radio presents have enormous sway over which songs gained popularity through airplay. Evans's personality and

choices could help shape the popularity of emerging bands, meaning further research could include how radio airplay influences chart success.

15. Matthew Bannister – https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Matthew_Bannister

Matthew Bannister is the Controller of BBC Radio 1, overseeing the programming and direction of the station. His decisions could affect which genres, artists, and presenters receive airtime. Bannister plays a major role in shaping the station's image and targeting younger audiences. This means delegates should look into the role of BBC Radio 1 in British music culture and broadcasting strategies.

16. John Peel – https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/John_Peel

John Peel is a BBC Radio 1 DJ known for discovering and promoting new music. His radio sessions are famous, meaning he can introduce many influential artists to wider audiences (such as The Smiths and Joy Division). Peel's credibility within the music industry makes his support incredibly valuable for emerging artists. Understanding his influence will help guide how he promotes different artists.

17. Keith Pringle – unfortunately no Wikipedia article, but this Guardian article could help <https://www.theguardian.com/media/2006/apr/20/gcapmedia.commercialradio>

Keith Pringle serves as the managing director of Capital Radio FM, one of London's most influential commercial radio stations. Unlike the BBC, commercial stations have to balance musical programming with advertising and audience ratings. Pringle's leadership can shape the station's playlists and business strategies.

18. Jarvis Cocker – https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Jarvis_Cocker

Jarvis Cocker is the frontman of Pulp and a major figure in the Britpop movement. His songwriting focuses on class, identity, and everyday British life (such as Pulp's 1995 album *Different Class*). Although Pulp competed with bands like Blur and Oasis, they also contributed to defining the musical culture of Britpop. Delegates should research Pulp's role in Britpop and Cocker's public persona.

19. Brett Anderson – https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Brett_Anderson

Brett Anderson is the lead singer of Suede, a band often cited by the press as helping to define the Britpop movement. Suede's music was a combination of glam with alternative rock (listen to *Beautiful Ones* and *Trash*).

20. Justine Frischmann – https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Justine_Frischmann

Justine Frischmann is the lead singer and guitarist of Elastica. She also helped to form Suede. Elastica are known for their distinctive style and catchy songwriting (listen to their song *Connection*).

21. Ian Brown – https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Ian_Brown

Ian Brown is the lead singer of The Stone Roses, a band cited as being foundational to the formation of the Britpop movement. Brown's reputation and legacy give him enormous credibility and sway within the British music scene. Have a look at the band's history and impact on later musicians, and how this may inform how he interacts with newer bands.

22. Tony Blair – https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Tony_Blair

Tony Blair is a leading figure in the Labour Party and the face of the emerging 'New Labour' political movement. He wants to modernise the party and appeal to younger voters. Blair's engagement with popular culture, including the Britpop scene, can help connect politics to youth culture. From this, delegates should research New Labour and Tony Blair's public persona.

23. Gordon Brown – https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Gordon_Brown

Gordon Brown serves as Shadow Chancellor to the Exchequer and is a key architect of New Labour's economic policies. His focus is on presenting Labour as economically responsible (especially in a post-Thatcherite Britain) while appealing to modern voters. Delegates should look into the economic and political debates of the 1990s and how this may guide Brown's priorities.

24. John Major – https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/John_Major

John Major serves as the Prime Minister for the Conservative Party. His government is facing internal party divisions and declining public support. He is governing during the rise of Britpop and a changing cultural face of the UK. Research should focus around his premiership and the political climate of the mid-1990s in order to inform how Major may act in committee.

25. John Redwood – https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/John_Redwood

John Redwood is a prominent Tory politician associated with the Eurosceptic wing of the party. In 1995, he challenged John Major's leadership, showing the Conservatives' internal divisions. Redwood represents a more traditional faction within British politics. Research should focus on the leadership challenge and broader debates within the Conservative Party to understand Redwood's potential strategy during debate.

QUESTIONS TO CONSIDER

1. How should you frame the Battle of Britpop? Is it a class divide of the working class North (Oasis) or the art school South (Blur)? How should this authenticity be portrayed? Could exploiting regional identity further affect the division?
2. In the wake of the EU's growing influence and debates around Euroscepticism, should Britpop be framed as proudly British, European, or globally exportable? How can this competition be used to strengthen Britain's global image?
3. What role should tabloids, the BBC, TV, and radio stations play in shaping the narrative of *Blur vs Oasis*? Should it be intensified to drive sales, or could overly sensationalising the charts battle make it disingenuous?
4. What responsibility do public figures have in portraying work, leisure, and national identity? How might these debates affect the political climate of the UK?

CLOSING REMARKS

In closing, this committee asks you to think beyond the question of which band will top the charts. The Battle of Britpop was not just a rivalry between Blur and Oasis, but a representation of a microcosm of a changing Britain grappling with class, identity, economic troubles, and its new place in an increasingly globalised world. Your characters – whether musicians, journalists, record executives, radio presents, or politicians – each have the power to shape public opinion and influence how this cultural movement unfolds.

As delegates, you should consider how political messaging, industry strategy, public behaviour, and media narratives interact with each other and also with music and youth culture. The choices you make in committee may determine not only who claims the Number 1 single, but also how the era of *Cool Britannia* is remembered. I encourage you all to immerse yourselves in the exciting year of 1995, collaborate with fellow delegates, and approach debate creatively, strategically, and curiously.

Above all, I hope you all enjoy bringing this important moment in British cultural history to life. I greatly look forward to watching how debate unfolds and the creative solutions you will come up with. Give this committee your best shot to *roll with it* (pun intended) and remember to go *hand in hand* (pun intended, again) with your fellow delegates!

Sincerely,

Head Chair Lydia Flynn

lcflynn@ucsd.edu

WORKS CITED

- Alao, Lola Christina. “What Does “Keep It Lemon” Mean? TikTok Trend Explained.” *The Standard*, Evening Standard, 6 Oct. 2023,
www.standard.co.uk/news/world/keep-it-lemon-meaning-tiktok-trend-b1111940.html.
- Ayto, John. “Movers and Shakers: A Chronology of Words That Shaped Our Age.” *Choice Reviews Online*, vol. 44, no. 09, 1 May 2007, pp. 44–477544–4775,
<https://doi.org/10.5860/choice.44-4775>.
- Brown, Colin. “The Major Minority.” *The Independent*, 13 Dec. 1996,
www.independent.co.uk/news/the-major-minority-1314246.html.
- Doward, Jamie. “Industrial Collapse of Thatcher Years Led to Crime Rise, Study Finds.” *The Guardian*, 27 Apr. 2019,
www.theguardian.com/politics/2019/apr/27/margaret-thatcher-industrial-collapse-led-to-crime-rise.
- Kersley, Andrew. “No, Margaret Thatcher Didn’t Save the British Economy.” *Jacobin.com*, 12 Oct. 2020, jacobin.com/2020/12/margaret-thatcher-british-economy-tories-austerity.
- McGuire, Stryker. “This Time I’ve Come to Bury Cool Britannia.” *The Guardian*, 29 Mar. 2009,
www.theguardian.com/politics/2009/mar/29/cool-britannia-g20-blair-brown.
- Muggs, Joe. “Twisting My Melon, Man! The Baggy, Brilliant Indie-Rave Summer of 1990.” *The Guardian*, The Guardian, 7 July 2020,
www.theguardian.com/music/2020/jul/07/1990s-indie-dance-boom-happy-mondays-prim-al-scream.
- Silverton, Peter. “Britpop | Bands, Songs, & Facts.” *Encyclopædia Britannica*, 2019,
www.britannica.com/art/Britpop.

Socialist Alternative Political Committee. “The Story of the 1984-85 Miners’ Strike - Socialist Alternative.” *Socialist Alternative*, 6 Mar. 2024,
socialistalternative.info/2024/03/06/the-story-of-the-1984-85-miners-strike/.

Sullivan, Caroline. “How We Made: Graham Coxon and Stephen Street on Parklife by Blur.” *The Guardian*, 16 July 2012,
www.theguardian.com/culture/2012/jul/16/how-we-made-blur-parklife.
